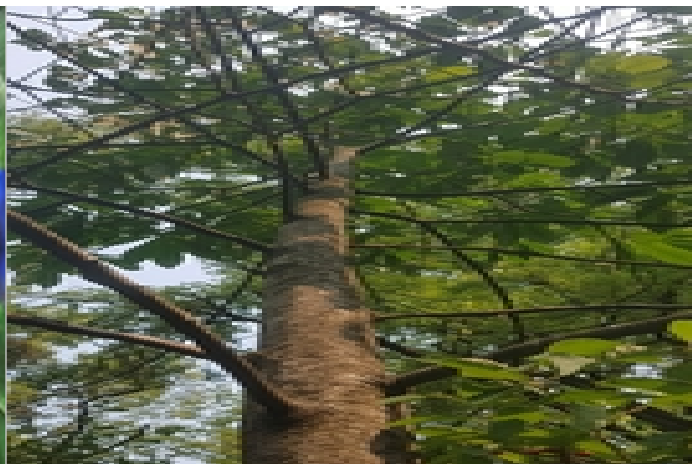


Pawpaw



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Missouri's largest native fruit. Custard-like yellow flesh with a tropical flavor — mango meets banana meets vanilla. Grows in shaded bottomland forest understory, often in patches.

American Persimmon



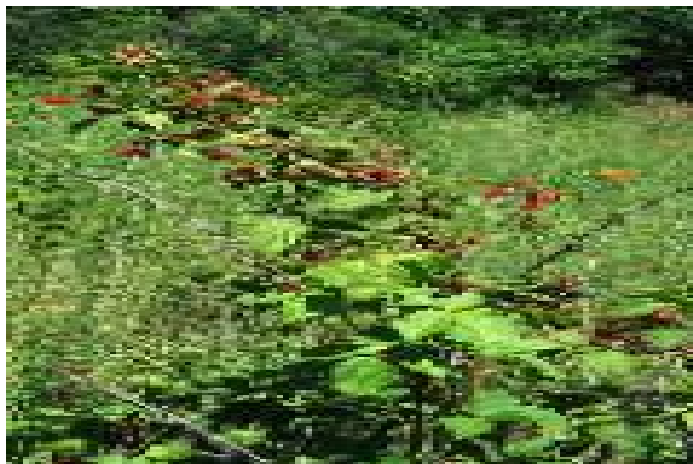
Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Small orange-purple fruit on a common understory tree. Intensely astringent until fully ripe — after first hard frost, turns sweet and rich. One of the best wild fruits in Missouri.

Wild Blackberry & Raspberry



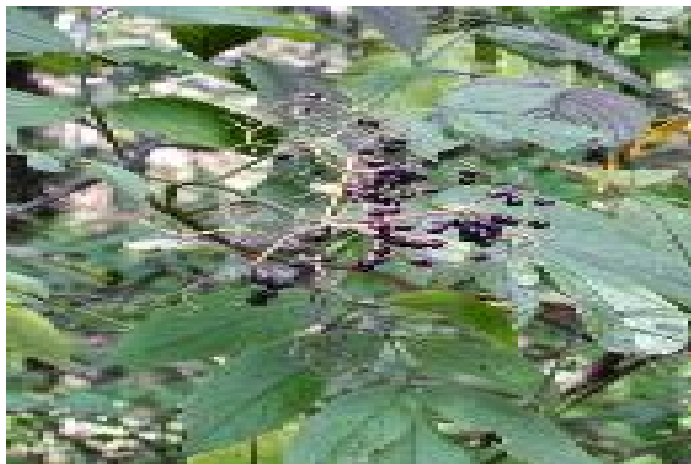
Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Thorny cane fruits found along roadsides, forest edges, and clearings. Blackberries ripen June–July; raspberries slightly earlier. Both are excellent eaten fresh, cooked, or preserved.

Elderberry



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Clusters of small dark purple-black berries on a large shrub with compound leaves. Found along streams and woodland edges statewide. Berries are edible cooked and used in syrup, wine, and preserves.

Red Mulberry



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

A native tree producing dark red-to-black elongated berries in June. Sweet, slightly tart. Common on forest edges and disturbed areas throughout Missouri. Leaves are highly variable in shape on the same tree.

Black Walnut



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Missouri's iconic nut tree. Rich, intensely flavored nuts inside a hard shell inside a green-black husk. Husks stain skin and surfaces indelibly. Nuts ripen and fall Sept–Oct.

Shagbark Hickory Nuts



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Sweet, rich nuts prized by wildlife and foragers alike. Identified by the tree's distinctively shaggy, peeling bark. Thin-shelled compared to other hickories. Found throughout the Ozarks and upland forests.

Wild Garlic / Ramps



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Pungent wild onion relatives. Ramps (wild leeks) appear in early spring in rich moist woods; wild garlic is common in fields and disturbed ground. Leaves, bulbs, and flowers all edible — strong onion/garlic flavor.

Cattail



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

One of the most useful wild plants — nearly every part is edible at some stage. Young spring shoots (like cucumbers), green flower spikes (like corn on the cob), yellow pollen (as flour supplement), and starchy roots year-round.

Dandelion



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Every part edible — young leaves in salads (bitter, nutritious), flowers in fritters or wine, roots roasted as coffee substitute. Most nutritious wild green available in early spring before leaves turn bitter.

Lamb's Quarters



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

A common "weed" of gardens and disturbed ground. Young leaves taste similar to spinach and are excellent sautéed or raw. Leaves often have a whitish, mealy coating. Extremely nutritious.

Watercress



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Peppery aquatic green growing in cool, clear springs and streams. Common in Ozark spring branches. Excellent flavor — use in salads and as garnish.

Wood Sorrel



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Clover-like plant with heart-shaped leaflets in groups of three. Bright, lemony-sour flavor from oxalic acid. Pink or yellow flowers. Found in lawns, gardens, and forest understory statewide.

Wild Strawberry



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Tiny but intensely flavorful wild version of the cultivated strawberry. Found in open woods, meadows, and roadsides, especially in the Ozarks. Ripens May–June. Five-petaled white flowers precede the fruit.

Serviceberry / Juneberry



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Small tree or shrub blooming white in early spring before most other trees leaf out. Berries ripen in June — purple-red, sweet, with a hint of almond from the seeds. Found throughout Ozark uplands.

Purslane



Primary view



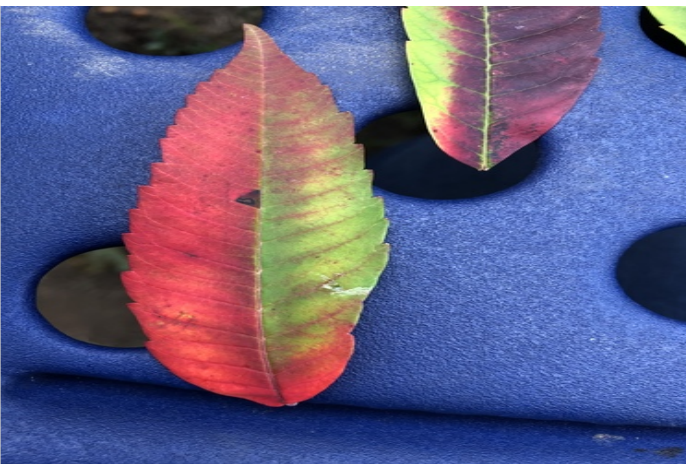
Fruit / seed / detail

Succulent-leaved sprawling plant found in gardens and disturbed soil. Slightly lemony, mucilaginous texture. High in omega-3 fatty acids — one of the most nutritious wild greens available.

Smooth Sumac



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Upright shrub with large compound leaves and dense clusters of velvety dark red berries. Common on roadsides, forest edges, and clearings. Berries used to make "sumac-ade" — a tart, lemonade-like drink steeped in water.

Poison Ivy



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Missouri's most encountered hazardous plant. "Leaves of three, let it be." Causes intensely itchy, blistering rash from urushiol oil. Can grow as a ground vine, shrub, or massive hairy climbing vine on trees.

Water Hemlock



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Considered the most violently toxic plant in North America. Found in wet meadows, stream banks, and marshes statewide. Resembles edible plants like wild parsnip, Queen Anne's lace, and water parsley. Roots are hollow and chambered.

Poison Hemlock



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

The plant that killed Socrates. Biennial herb with hollow purple-spotted stems, fernlike leaves, and flat-topped white flower clusters. Increasingly common in Missouri roadsides, disturbed ground, and stream edges. Smells mousy when crushed.

Pokeweed



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Imposing plant growing 4–10 feet tall with dark purple-black berries in elongated clusters on magenta-pink stems. Found in disturbed areas, forest edges, and roadsides statewide. Birds eat berries without harm — humans cannot.

White Snakeroot



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

A common woodland plant with clusters of small white flowers. Historically caused "milk sickness" — the disease that killed Abraham Lincoln's mother Nancy Hanks, contracted from drinking milk from cows that grazed on this plant.

Jimsonweed / Datura



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Rank-smelling plant with large white trumpet-shaped flowers and spiny seed pods. Found in disturbed soil, roadsides, and pastures across Missouri. All parts contain tropane alkaloids (atropine, scopolamine, hyoscyamine).

Death Camas



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Grass-like leaves arising from a bulb, with creamy-white flowers on a tall spike. Found in open woods, prairies, and glades — especially Ozark glades. Looks similar to wild onion/garlic but has NO onion odor.

Mayapple



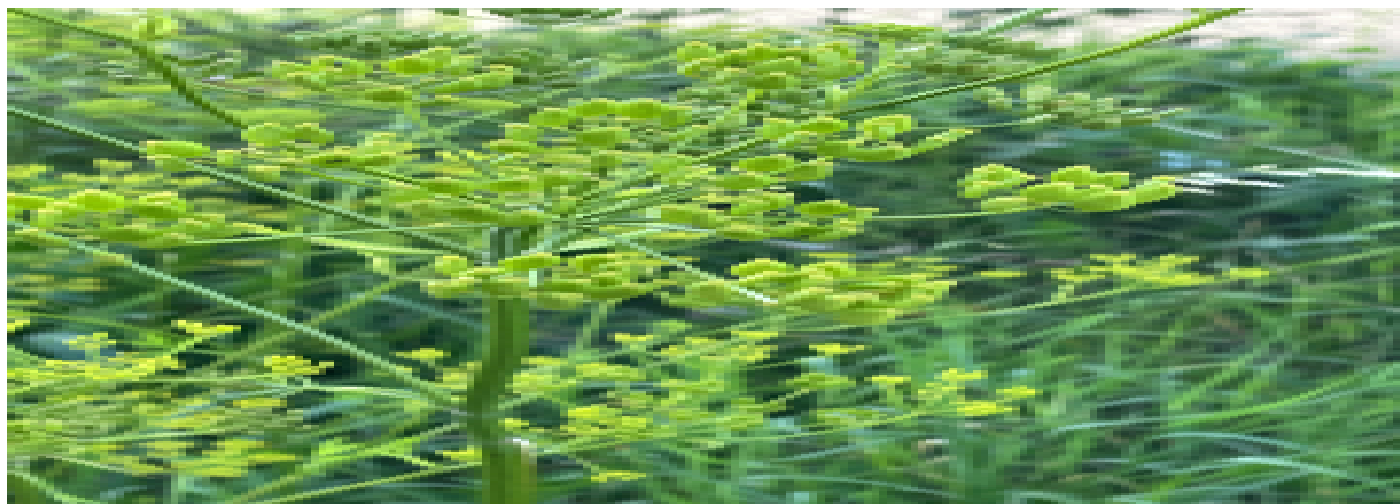
Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

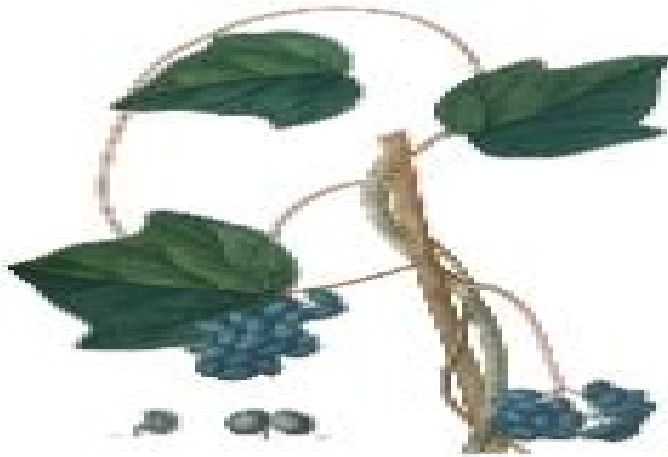
Large umbrella-like leaves carpet woodland floors in spring. A single white flower blooms under the leaf pair. The yellow egg-shaped fruit, when fully ripe (late summer), is edible and lemon-flavored.

Wild Parsnip



Yellow-flowered plant in the carrot family found along roadsides. The sap causes phototoxic chemical burns — blistering and long-lasting brown scarring when skin contacts sap and is then exposed to sunlight.

Moonseed



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

A climbing vine producing clusters of dark blue-black berries resembling wild grapes. Found along forest edges and stream banks across Missouri. The key difference: moonseed has a single crescent-shaped seed; wild grapes have round seeds.

Nightshade



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Two species common in Missouri. Black nightshade has small white star-shaped flowers and green-to-black berries. Bittersweet nightshade is a climbing vine with purple flowers and red berries. Both are toxic.

Ohio Buckeye



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Missouri's native buckeye tree. Produces distinctive round brown nuts with a smooth, shiny patch. The nuts are a classic "lucky charm" carried in pockets — but they are toxic if eaten raw.

Poison Sumac



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

A tall shrub or small tree found only in wet, boggy habitats — swamps, bogs, and wet bottomlands. Unlike safe sumacs, poison sumac has white or cream-colored berries in loose clusters, not red berries in tight heads.

Trumpet Creeper



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Common and beautiful native vine with spectacular orange-red tubular flowers, beloved by hummingbirds. Climbs trees, fences, and structures across Missouri. Leaves, stems, and flowers can cause contact dermatitis in sensitive individuals.

Morel



Missouri's most celebrated wild mushroom. The honeycomb-pitted cap is unmistakable. Found in spring (April–May) near dying elms, old orchards, cottonwoods, and ash trees. Both yellow and black morels occur in Missouri.

Chicken of the Woods



Unmistakable bright orange and yellow shelf fungus growing in overlapping fans on living or dead oaks and other hardwoods. Can weigh many pounds. Summer through fall. Tastes remarkably chicken-like when young and tender.

Hen of the Woods / Maitake



Massive clusters of overlapping gray-brown fronds growing at the base of oaks, often the same tree year after year. Fruit bodies can weigh 20+ pounds. Earthy, rich flavor. Found September–November.

Chanterelle



Golden-yellow funnel-shaped mushroom with forking false gills (ridges that run down the stem). Found in mixed oak-hickory forest, especially after rain in summer. Fruity, apricot-like aroma.

Oyster Mushroom



White to gray shelf mushrooms growing in clusters on dead hardwoods, particularly cottonwoods and elms. Gills run down a stubby off-center stem. Mild, savory flavor. Found spring and fall, sometimes in winter during warm spells.

Giant Puffball



White round to oval ball, often soccer-ball sized, found in meadows, fields, and open woods in summer. Edible only when the interior is pure white throughout — once any yellow or purple coloration appears, it is past edibility.

Lion's Mane



White, shaggy, icicle-like teeth hanging in a single clump from the wounds of living hardwoods, especially oaks and beeches. Found late summer through fall. Texture and flavor often compared to crab or lobster.

Death Cap



Responsible for the majority of fatal mushroom poisonings worldwide. Pale green to yellowish-white cap, white gills, white stem with a ring and a cup-like volva at the base. Found in Missouri associated with oaks. Has a pleasant smell and mild taste.

Destroying Angel



Pure white from cap to base — gills, stem, and all. Found in oak-hickory forest in summer and fall. Contains the same amatoxins as the death cap. Has been mistaken for button mushrooms, puffballs (when immature), or edible *Amanita* species.

Jack-o'-Lantern



Bright orange mushroom growing in large clusters at the base of oaks or from buried roots. Gills glow faintly in the dark (a unique feature). Frequently mistaken for chanterelles. Causes severe gastrointestinal distress.

False Morel



A spring mushroom resembling a morel, with a wrinkled, brain-like or saddle-shaped reddish-brown cap. The cap is irregularly lobed and only partially attached to the stem (not fully attached as in true morels). Interior is chambered, not hollow.

Galerina marginata



Small brown mushroom with a ring on the stem, growing on decaying wood, often in tight clusters. Contains the same deadly amatoxins as the death cap. Frequently mistaken for oyster mushrooms, honey mushrooms, or other edible wood-growers.

Fly Agaric



Iconic red or orange-red cap with white warts, white gills, and a ringed stem. The classic storybook toadstool. Occasionally found in Missouri. Contains ibotenic acid and muscimol — psychoactive and toxic.

Copperhead



Missouri's most common venomous snake. Stout body with distinctive hourglass-shaped crossbands in chestnut and copper tones. Found statewide in rocky, wooded terrain, brush piles, and forest edges. Mostly nocturnal in hot weather.

Cottonmouth / Water Moccasin



Heavy-bodied semi-aquatic pit viper. Adults are dark olive to black; juveniles have copperhead-like banding. Found near water in southern and southeastern Missouri — swamps, sloughs, rivers, and ponds of the Bootheel and Ozark border lowlands. Shows the white interior of its mouth when threatened (the "cotton").

Timber Rattlesnake



Missouri's largest venomous snake, reaching 4–5 feet. Heavy-bodied with a distinctive rattle and a dark tail. Found in rocky bluffs, talus slopes, and upland forests — especially Ozark ridges. Dens communally in winter.

Western Pygmy Rattlesnake



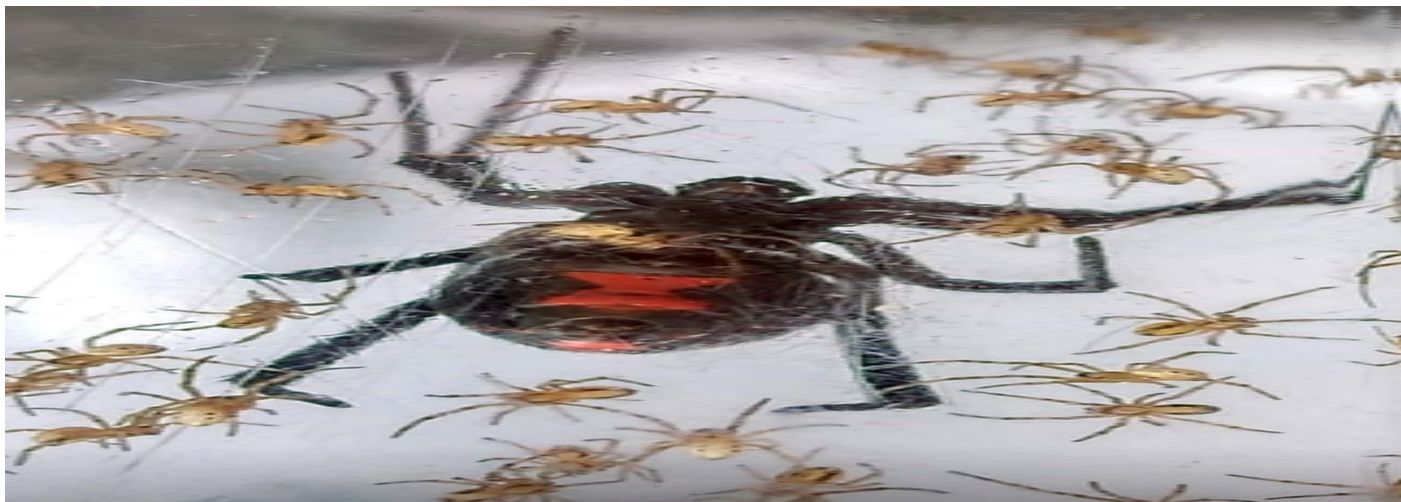
A small, 18-24 inch rattlesnake with a tiny rattle barely audible beyond a few feet. Grayish with dark blotches. Found in southwestern Missouri, particularly rocky glades and cedar woods. Easy to step on without hearing.

Brown Recluse Spider



Missouri is within the core range of this medically significant spider. Tan to brown, 1/4–3/4 inch body, with a violin-shaped darker marking on the back. Found in undisturbed areas: basements, woodpiles, storage boxes, clothing, shoes.

Black Widow Spider



Shiny black spider with the iconic red hourglass marking on the underside of the abdomen. Females are the dangerous sex; males are tiny and rarely bite. Found under rocks, boards, woodpiles, and in outbuildings across Missouri.

Lone Star Tick



The most common tick in Missouri. Females have a distinctive white dot on their back. Transmits several diseases including ehrlichiosis, tularemia, STARI (Southern tick-associated rash illness), and — critically — can trigger Alpha-Gal Syndrome, causing lifelong red meat allergy.

Black-Legged (Deer) Tick



Small tick — nymphs are poppy-seed sized, making them very easy to miss. Primary vector of Lyme disease in the eastern US. Adults are most active in fall (increasing risk in October–November) and early spring. Found in wooded and brushy habitat.

Snapping Turtle



Large aquatic turtle found in virtually every body of water in Missouri. Can weigh 35+ pounds. On land, they are defensive and will strike with remarkable speed. In water, they are generally docile and avoid humans.

Feral Hog



Invasive and expanding across southern Missouri. Can reach 200–400 pounds. Normally avoids humans, but cornered individuals or sows with young are dangerous. Tusks can cause serious wounds. Highly destructive to habitat.

White-Tailed Deer



Missouri's most important game animal. Abundant statewide. Lean, flavorful venison is nutritionally excellent. Missouri has one of the highest deer harvests in the nation, with an exceptionally long season.

Wild Turkey



Missouri has one of the densest wild turkey populations in the country, following remarkable conservation recovery. Found statewide in forest-edge habitat. Spring gobbler and fall season available. Far superior table fare to domestic turkey.

Eastern Cottontail



Missouri's most abundant small game animal. Found in brushy areas, wood edges, and gardens statewide. Lean, mild white meat similar to chicken. Excellent in stews and braises. Best harvested after the first frost reduces parasite risk.

Gray & Fox Squirrel



Both species are excellent table fare, historically a staple of Missouri cuisine. Fox squirrels are larger; gray squirrels are smaller and faster. Gray squirrels prefer dense forest; fox squirrels prefer open woodland and forest edges.

Channel Catfish



Missouri's most popular sport fish. Found in virtually every river, lake, and large pond in the state. Missouri rivers produce trophy-sized channel cats. Excellent white, mild, firm flesh — superb fried or grilled.

Largemouth Bass

Found in ponds, lakes, and slow-moving rivers throughout Missouri. The state's most popular sport fish. Good to excellent eating when cleaned promptly and cooled. Mild, white, flaky meat.

Crappie



Both white and black crappie are found in Missouri lakes and rivers. Among the best-tasting freshwater fish available — delicate, white, flaky meat prized by anglers. Schooling fish; when you find them, the catching is excellent.

Ozark Smallmouth Bass



The Ozark Highlands' signature sport fish. Found in the clear, gravel-bottomed spring-fed streams of the Ozarks — the Jacks Fork, Current, Eleven Point, Big Piney, and countless others. A world-class sport fish in a stunning natural setting.

Bullfrog



The largest North American frog. Common in ponds, lakes, and slow streams statewide. Frog legs are a Missouri delicacy — mild, white meat often described as tasting like chicken. Gigging (spearing at night) is the traditional harvest method.

Crayfish



Dozens of crayfish species inhabit Missouri's streams — the Ozarks have exceptional diversity, including many endemic species. Common crayfish are excellent boiled in seasoned water and eaten like small crawfish. Excellent protein source from clear Ozark streams.

Canada Goose



Abundant in Missouri, particularly along the Missouri and Mississippi flyways and in agricultural areas. Rich, dark breast meat with deep flavor — prepared correctly, one of the finest wild birds. Often unfairly maligned due to poor preparation.

Mallard Duck



Missouri sits on the Mississippi Flyway and attracts extraordinary waterfowl numbers in migration. Mallards, teal, pintails, and dozens of other species stage in Missouri wetlands. Stuttgart to the south may be the duck hunting capital of the world.

Raccoon



Abundant throughout Missouri. Raccoon meat — especially from young animals — has a long tradition in Missouri cooking, particularly in rural areas. Rich, dark meat best prepared slow-cooked or roasted with root vegetables. Historically an important food source.

Virginia Opossum



North America's only marsupial. Common throughout Missouri. "Possum" has a long culinary tradition in Missouri and the broader South. Fat animals in fall are best. Historically prepared by parboiling then roasting with sweet potatoes.

Snapping Turtle (Table)



Considered excellent table fare by many Missouri outdoorspeople. Seven distinct muscle types produce varied textures and flavors. Traditionally prepared in snapping turtle soup — a Missouri river-town tradition. Found in virtually every body of water.

Bluegill



Missouri's most abundant sunfish — the quintessential beginner fish, found in every pond and lake, prized for sweet white fillets.

Walleye



Missouri's premier cool-water sport fish with glassy eyes adapted for night hunting. Widely regarded as the finest-tasting freshwater fish in North America.

Flathead Catfish



Missouri's largest native catfish — a trophy predator reaching 60+ lbs with a distinctive flat head and protruding lower jaw. Exclusive live-bait hunter.

Blue Catfish



North America's largest catfish species — Missouri River and Mississippi River giants regularly exceed 80 lbs. Blue-gray, spotless sides and straight anal fin distinguish it.

White Bass



A schooling, migratory fish famous for spectacular spring spawning runs below Missouri dams. Striped sides, fast action, and excellent eating make it a spring tradition.

Paddlefish



A 65-million-year-old filter-feeder with a paddle-shaped snout. Missouri's most ancient fish — taken only by snagging in spring. Prized roe rivals Beluga caviar.

Rainbow Trout



Stocked in Missouri's 4 Ozark trout parks and Taneycomo tailwater. The pink lateral stripe and black spots make it unmistakable. Missouri's most-visited fishing destination.

Alligator Gar



North America's largest freshwater fish — up to 8 feet and 300 lbs in SE Missouri's Mississippi backwaters. Ancient armored predator with dual rows of teeth. ROE IS TOXIC.

White-tailed Deer



Heart-shaped split hoof, 2–3.5" long. Two pointed halves that register as a V-shape. Dewclaws print behind and to the sides in soft mud or running deer. Walking stride ~18"; running leaps can exceed 15 feet.

Wild Turkey



Three large forward toes + one small rear toe (hallux). Tracks 3.5–4.5" long, splayed. Tracks register alternately in a straddled walk. Toms make longer strides than hens. Drag marks between prints common in winter.

Feral Hog



Rounder, blunter toes than deer — less pointed. Dewclaws ALWAYS visible even on hard ground (deer dewclaws only show in soft mud). Wider spread between halves. Often travel in groups (sounders), leaving churned mud.

Coyote



Oval print, 4 toes with claws (claws always show in canines). 2–2.5" long. Trot gait produces a nearly single-file trail — prints nearly in a straight line. Distinguish from domestic dog: coyote trails are purposeful and straight; dogs meander.

Red Fox



Smaller, more elliptical than coyote (1.75–2.25"). Claws show. The red fox produces the most perfectly straight trail of any Missouri canine — hind foot lands precisely in front print. Dense fur between toe pads may cause fuzzy look in winter tracks.

Bobcat



Round print (1.5–2.5"), NO claw marks (retracted claws). 4 round toe pads. Distinctive 3-lobed leading edge on heel pad. Rarely seen but tracks common throughout Missouri. Cat tracks are rounder, dog tracks more oval.

Raccoon



The most distinctive Missouri track. Front print: 5 long finger-like toes, ~3". Hind: 5 toes, wider heel, ~4" — looks like a tiny human hand and foot together. Packhorse gait: hind foot beside front foot, printing in pairs.

Virginia Opossum



Unmistakable hind print: 5 toes with an opposable thumb-like hallux pointing sideways at 90°. Hallux has NO claw. Front has 5 pointed toes. Tail drag line often visible. Waddling gait with 2-print groups offset.

Eastern Cottontail



Classic bound: large hind feet land AHEAD of smaller front feet in a Y-shape or trapezoid. Hind prints 3–4" long; fronts 1–1.5". Four prints per bound group. Hind prints side by side and slightly angled. The go-to Missouri small game animal.

American Beaver



Huge webbed hind print (up to 6"). Small 4-toed front. Wide tail drag mark often obliterates the tracks. Near water — always. Beaver sign is usually more obvious than the tracks: gnawed stumps with pointed tips, dams, lodges, scent mounds.

American Black Bear



Front: wide, 5 toes in a curved arc with long curved claws, 4–5". Hind: 7–9", looks remarkably like a large human barefoot print with 5 toes and a distinct heel. Only Missouri mammal with such large humanoid hind tracks.

River Otter



Webbed 5-toed print, 3–4.5". Round with partial webbing showing. Loping gait produces 2×2 print groups. Most distinctive sign: otter slide — a chute-like impression in mud or snow on riverbanks where otters slide repeatedly for what appears to be play.

Striped Skunk



5 toes on both front and hind. Front claws extremely long (for digging) — often the most distinctive feature: claws can extend 1" beyond toe pads. Hind claws short. Slow, waddling walk. Musk smell often present in area before tracks are found.

Muskrat



Small (1–1.5") 5-toed prints with a thin, sinuous tail drag line that snakes between the prints — the signature feature. Partially webbed hind feet. Near water, always. Muskrat sign is often more obvious than tracks: push-ups (mounded vegetation in frozen water) and cattail lodges.

White Oak



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail



Bur Oak

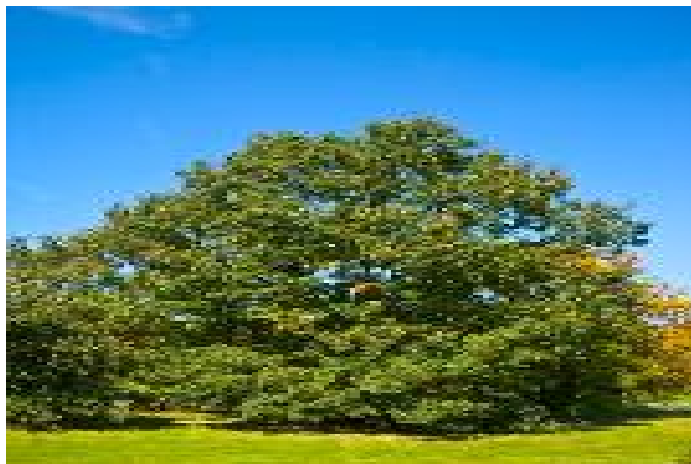


Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Black Oak



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Chinkapin Oak

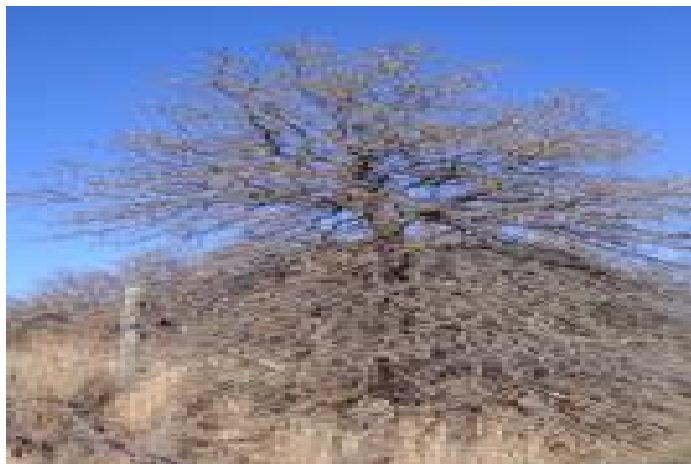


Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Blackjack Oak



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Shumard Oak



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Shagbark Hickory



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Shellbark Hickory



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Mockernut Hickory



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Bitternut Hickory



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Pecan



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Black Walnut



Primary view



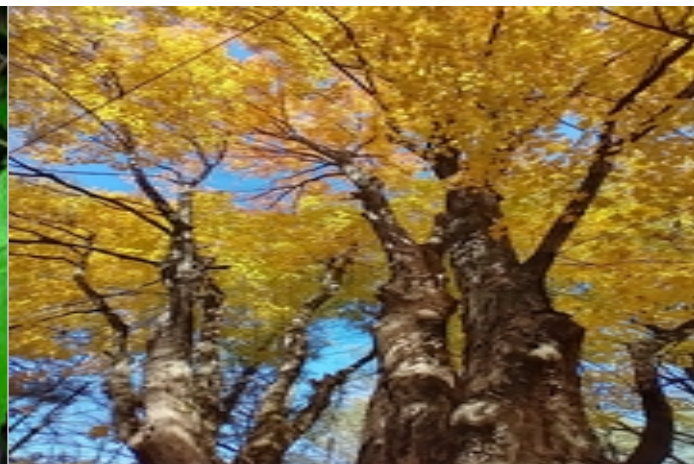
Fruit / seed / detail



Sugar Maple



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail



Silver Maple



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Boxelder



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

White Ash



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail



American Elm



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Slippery Elm



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Eastern Redbud



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Flowering Dogwood



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail



Osage Orange



Primary view

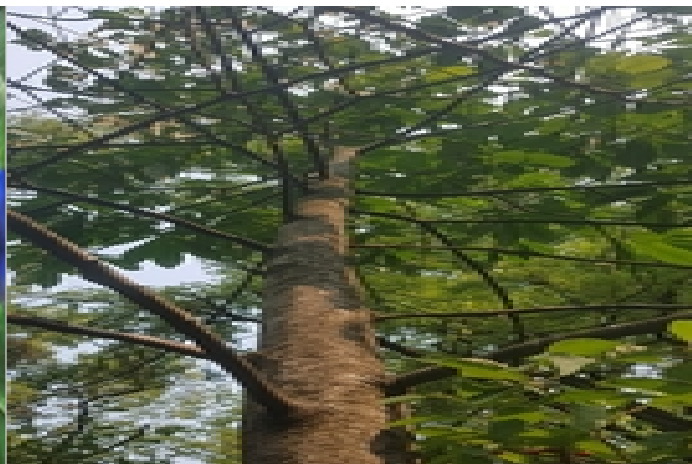


Fruit / seed / detail

Pawpaw



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail



Sassafras



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Sycamore



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Shortleaf Pine



Primary view

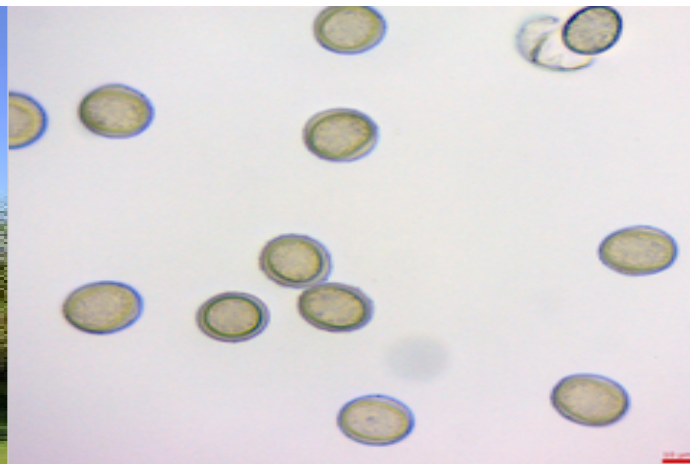


Fruit / seed / detail

Eastern Red Cedar



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Persimmon



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

Black Cherry



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail



Honey Locust



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail



Kentucky Coffeetree



Primary view



Fruit / seed / detail

■ Snakebite Protocol

If bitten by a venomous snake in Missouri:

■ Mushroom Poisoning

If you suspect mushroom poisoning — even without immediate symptoms:

Plant Poisoning / Poison Control

Missouri Poison Center:1-800-222-1222(24 hours, free)

True Morel vs. False Morel

✓ True Morel (Safe)

Wild Grape vs. Moonseed

✓ Wild Grape (Edible)

Wild Onion vs. Death Camas

✓ Wild Onion / Garlic (Safe)

Chanterelle vs. Jack-o'-Lantern

✓ Chanterelle (Edible)

Identifying Missouri's Venomous Snakes

Missouri has four venomous snake species. Key field identifiers:

Tick Bite Prevention & Removal

Safe Foraging Rules for Missouri
